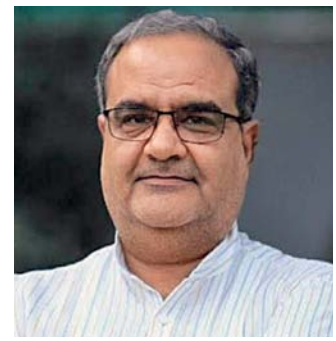






MANEESH AGNIHOTRI

PECKING ORDER Far left, Yogi Adityanath with deputy CM Keshav Prasad Maurya; left, the new general secretary (organisation) Dharampal Singh; bottom, new state unit chief Bhupendra Singh Chaudhary

UP BJP

GOINGS-ON ON THE GOMTI

deputy CM Keshav Prasad Maurya are associated with the east.

Chaudhary, a Jat and a minister in the Yogi cabinet, has worked in the party organisation for over 25 years. His community, though only 9-10 per cent of UP's total voters, is a powerful presence in several western districts. In the previous Lok Sabha polls, the BJP had won only 19 of 27 seats in western UP. Chaudhary is expected to consolidate the BJP's traditional Jat votes that were slipping away post the farmers' protests.

Bijnor native Dharampal, earlier general secretary (organisation) for Jharkhand, was seen to have been key in fetching massive wins for the saffron party with his pre-poll work in the Kashi region. That's why a section in the BJP feels he can fill the space created by his predecessor, Sunil Bansal, often credited as an enabler in the party's victories in the state since 2014. Bansal, now redesignated as general secretary for Telangana, Odisha and West Bengal, was seen as Delhi's man in Lucknow and, as an entity loyal more to the organisation than the government, did not necessarily share the best chemistry with Yogi. Another section in the party thinks the road ahead will stay less than smooth due to a lack of coordination between party and government.

THE NEW STATE UNIT CHIEF AND GEN SECY (ORGANISATION) ARE BOTH FROM WESTERN UP, THE IDEA BEING REGIONAL BALANCE

The day Dharampal held his first meeting with party functionaries in Ghaziabad, Maurya tweeted a cryptic line, "The organisation is bigger than the government!" His tweet landed at a time when the BJP was still searching for a new state party chief and Maurya was a strong contender for the post. His tweet was also interpreted by many as an attempt to show the mirror to the chief minister's office, which is allegedly functioning as the only power centre.

As for votes, the BJP is exploring catchment areas beyond its old social coalition of dominant castes, non-Yadav OBCs and non-Jatav Dalits. Indeed, buoyed by its recent win in the Azamgarh Lok Sabha bypoll, it plans to conduct raids into the heart of the Opposition's vote base: primarily the Samajwadi Party's Muslim-Yadav bloc and the BSP's Jatav phalanx. Says a BJP senior, "Our new targets are Pasmanda Muslims, Yadavs and Jatavs." Visible representation is key to the outreach: the party has sent ex-MLA Sunita Yadav to the Rajya Sabha, Jaunpur MLA Girish Chandra Yadav is a minister, and former Bharatiya Janata Yuva Morcha state chief Subhash Yaduvanshi was recently made an MLC. The pre-poll induction of Aparna Yadav, *bahu* of the Mulayam family, was part of this.

The Pasmanda imprint on its poll performances, growing since 2014, gives the party cause for optimism. Community leaders have been named to key positions—Danish Azad Ansari is a minister; Iftikar Ahmed Javed is chairman, UP Board of Madarsa Education; and Choudhary Kaif-ul-Wara, from the weaver community, is UP Urdu Akademi chairman. Similarly, Jatavs too are being drafted into district units. Says state BJP spokesperson Rakesh Tripathi, "We have a reach in every section of society. That's why we could win seats like Rampur and Azamgarh. We are confident of winning tough seats in future also." ■